

crowded the Jews who under some unknown inspiration and leadership had started the work. Their second attempt failed, and the cause of their failure was the presence of a personality against whom their utmost struggles were in vain.

§ 10. THE DATE OF EZRA'S MISSION.

It has been assumed in the preceding pages that Ezra belongs to a later period than Nehemiah. That conclusion seems to me inevitable. It is true that the editor of the books thought otherwise. His placing of *Ezr.* 7-10 before *Ne.* 1 shows that the Artaxerxes who authorised Ezra's administration was, in his view, the same as the Artaxerxes who appointed Nehemiah to be governor of Judah, and his placing of the promulgation of the law by Ezra (*Ne.* 8¹⁻¹²) in the midst of Nehemiah's rule shows his belief that they were contemporaries. Further to support his view, he has introduced Nehemiah in the story of the reading of the law (*Ne.* 8⁹). He also drags Ezra's name into the story of the dedication of the walls (*Ne.* 12³⁶), but it is a manifest gloss. In spite of the dissimilarity of their work, these two leaders could not be contemporaries.

For Art. would scarcely send two men to Judah at the same time, both clothed with similar powers. It would be strange, were Ezra such a prominent figure in Jerus., that there is no genuine reference to him in Neh.'s story. Neh. in his second administration was the first to discover mixed marriages and to apply a sharp remedy. Such a condition would not arise naturally after the wholesale dissolution as described in *Ezr.* 9 *f.* Neh.'s reforms, as narrated in c. 13, would be strange after Ezra, but are very natural before his time. It is inconceivable that the Lev. should be driven to work in the fields directly after Ezra's mission, or even possibly while it lasted. The measures Neh. took for the support of the temple show that his action could not have been preceded by the rule of a scribe-priest with ample authority to enforce the law. Moreover, the Jerus. of Neh.'s time was a desolation, without walls or houses or people (7⁴). Ezra's whole career is spent in the holy city, and there appears to have been plenty of houses and people in his time.

There is the evidence of *Esd.* which connects *Ne.* 7¹²-8¹³ directly with *Ezr.* 10, thus bringing the Ezra story together. There is nothing about Neh.'s work in this the earliest edition of our books. *Jos.* has a section dealing with Neh.'s administration (*Ant.* xi, 5, 6-8). Before